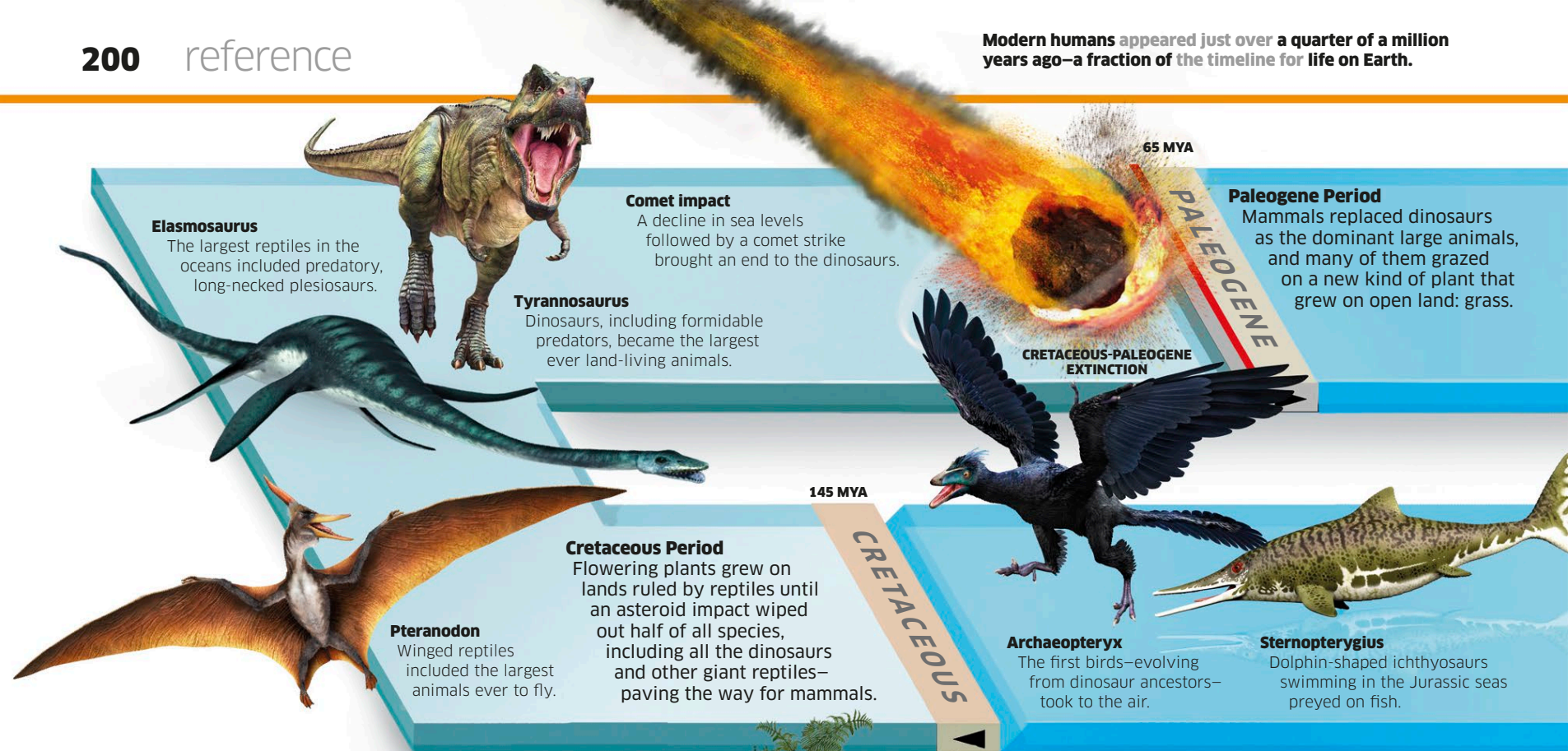




Timeline of life

Half a billion years ago the only living things were small and simple. Over time, evolution has produced a spectacular world of plants and animals.

The timeline of life is divided into periods that were dominated by particular kinds of organisms—such as invertebrates, fishes, or reptiles. As the surface of Earth changed, some organisms succeeded, while others died away. Continents shifted, seas rose and fell, and luxuriant forests turned into parched deserts and back again. Catastrophes, such as asteroid strikes or ice ages, even drove some major groups to extinction. Such events all made their mark on living things. However, throughout the history of Earth, life went on as descendants after descendants eventually led to the natural world we know today.

